KERALA

THEATRE OF WAR

Prominent missing faces, sulking veterans and wannabes, a fresh batch of heirs heat up the assembly poll arena in Kerala

Party general secretary M.A. Baby stopped short of naming him as the chief ministerial candidate, invoking the party tradition of deferring that "democratic" decision to the post-poll phase. He also did not confirm whether Pinarayi would contest from Dharmadom, his home constituency in Kannur, which he has represented since 2016 and from where he has led the Left's obdurate, decade-long electoral dominance over a pugnacious Congress and an aspirational Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

Less slim gaps opened up for other prominent faces too. The CPI(M) has 61 MLAs and three allied independents in the 140-member assembly. The state secretariat has cleared the decks for 50 of those for a recontest. But former finance minister Thomas Isaac's name is conspicuously absent.

Two formal filters are in play here. A two-term bar stands relaxed for many of the 50. This includes Pinarayi, who will be contesting to be a fifth-time legislator, the first occasion having come 56 years ago, in 1970, when he entered the House as a street-smart, 25-year-old apparatchik.

That favour has apparently not been extended to the 73-year-old Isaac, economist and former state planning board member who was once a professor at Thiruvananthapuram's Centre for Development Studies. Also, for seat-specific names, by party protocol, district secretariats make the first recommendation. Earlier, speculation linked the soft-spoken Isaac to two constituencies: Aroor or Thiruvananthapuram. But his name didn't figure in the lists from either.

NO LEEWAY FOR ICONS

K.K. Shailaja, former health minister, is another malcontent. Popularly known as Shailaja Teacher, she had gained iconicity in the first Pinarayi cabinet with her able stewardship during the COVID pandemic. Famously, she got dropped in the next cabinet. That was despite clear signs of immense popularity: she had brought in the highest-margin victory in the 2021 assembly poll, from Mattannur, with 60,963 votes. She didn't complain then, sticking to the CPI(M)'s stoic homilies about "teamwork", welcoming "new faces" and saying there was "no need to be emotional".

This time, the strain is showing. In its February 28 meeting, the state secretariat made it known that it wants her to shift out from Mattannur, the seat where she registered the record-breaking win for the party last time. In the past, she has represented Peravoor (2006) and Koothuparamba (1996, 2016). The CPI(M) leadership wants to field her from Peravoor, which was won last time by Congress veteran Sunny Joseph, now the party's state chief.

The CPI(M)'s logic: Mattannur is a stronghold, any leader can win from there, and she must go head to head against Joseph to try maximise the party's scorecard. "We will field the best candidates in every seat to improve our tally," Baby tells INDIA TODAY. "Media need not worry." The dust will settle, or perhaps not, after the final list of LDF



K.K. SHAILAJA, *69*

In dissent mode after being told to shift out of her record win seat

PINARAYI VIJAYAN, *80*

Contesting to be a fifth-time legislator, has had age and two-time bar relaxed. Named to "lead LDF", not 'projected' as CM



SHONE GEORGE, *42*

Old Christian stalwart P.C. George—and his son—now frontrunners for saffron